speech but should be avoided in writing.

Just because Just because I want to be a doctor doesn't mean I will get into medical school.

Revised Simply wanting to be a doctor doesn't guarantee admission to medical school.

Revised Although I want to be a doctor, I will need to work hard to get into medical school.

H 5. Words and Language

The English language is rich and always evolving, offering you many ways and words to express yourself in writing and speech.

Language Varieties

English is not one language but many, made up of regional and social dialects. In addition, groups speak using specialized language among themselves that can be difficult for outsiders to understand. As a writer, be aware of the audience for your writing. Use language that your readers will understand directly or from context.

Dialects

English **dialects** are distinctive versions of the language used in geographical regions and/or by particular social or ethnic groups. Standard American English, the English spoken by newscasters, is one such dialect, as are African American Vernacular English, Creole, Appalachian English, and others. English dialects have many features in common, but each has particulars of grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation. (For an in-depth discussion of dialects and academic writing, see Spotlight on … Variations of English.)

Slang

Groups of people with similar skills and interests often develop **slang** that allows them to express ideas quickly and vividly. Slang also signals knowledge about a particular topic, such as meme culture, music, sports, and more. Slang is generally considered too casual for most academic writing, but it may be appropriate for personal essays. In your papers, be aware of your purpose and audience when choosing to use slang. Avoid using slang that your readers are unlikely to understand.

Technical Expressions

Experts in many professional fields use specialized and technical expressions that allow them to communicate efficiently and clearly with each other. Such language is often incomprehensible for nonexperts and should be avoided in writing for general readers. (For tips on writing about a technical topic for an audience of nonspecialists, see Spotlight on … Discipline-Specific and Technical Language.)

Biased Language

Biased words and expressions exclude or demean people on the basis of gender, sex, sexual orientation, age, ethnicity, social class, or physical or mental traits.

Biased Language Based on Sex and Gender

English includes words and expressions that are considered biased based on sex and gender, such as *mankind, businessman, chairman, fireman,* and so on. These are commonly replaced by gender-neutral words such as *humanity, businessperson, chair* or *chairperson,* and *firefighter.* (See Spotlight on … Bias in Language and Research for more on language bias.)

In addition, the English pronoun *he* has traditionally been used as the gender-neutral pronoun. For example, the construction *A doctor should have a caring attitude toward his patients* was once common but is now widely viewed as gender biased because many doctors are not men. For a discussion of the pronoun *he* used as the gender-neutral pronoun, see Pronouns.

Labels and Stereotypes

Be sensitive to labels and stereotypes that may insult a group of people you are writing about. Avoid labels that don't put people first, such as *cancer victim* and *wheelchair-bound.* Don't make assumptions about entire groups of people that promote stereotypes, such as *teenagers are rebellious, elderly people don't hear well, conservatives are rich,* or *women are more emotional than men.* (See Spotlight on ... Bias in Language and Research for more on language bias.)

Exact Words

As a general rule, use plain, direct words in your writing. Avoid reaching for a word that sounds fancy or impressive, especially if you are unsure about the meaning. If you use a word that is only vaguely familiar to you, look it up in a dictionary to ensure you are using it correctly. (You can type the word and "def" to get a definition.) Doing so has the added benefit of building your vocabulary.

Words Commonly Confused

The words in the following list are commonly confused or misused by writers. As you write, consult this list or use a reliable online tool, such as Merriam-Webster (https://openstax.org/r/merriam-webster), to check the meanings and usage of words you're unsure of. Keep a list of words that cause you trouble as you become aware of them. Then, after you draft a document, do a search for the words on your list. (For a discussion of homonyms, homographs, and homophones, see Editing Focus: Words Often Confused.)

Confusing Words	Definitions and Examples
accept, except	*Accept* means "to receive willingly." *Except* is used mostly as a preposition meaning "excluding." *He accepted all the gifts except mine.*
advice, advise	*Advice* is a noun meaning "guidance." *Advise* is a verb meaning "to recommend." *My mother gives good advice when she advises me about my college courses.*
affect, effect	The verb a*ffect* means "to produce a change in." The noun *effect* means "result." *The wine affected me, but it seemed to have no effect on my roommate.*
all ready, already	*All ready* means "completely prepared." *Already* means "happened by or before now." *We were all ready for the trip, but the train had already left.*
all right, alright	*All right* is always two words meaning "acceptable" or "satisfactory." *Alright* is an informal spelling.
all together, altogether	*All together* means "everyone or everything together." *We put the tickets all together for safekeeping. Altogether* means "completely" or "entirely." *The book is altogether incomprehensible.*
allusion, illusion	An *allusion* is an indirect or implied reference. *The poem includes an allusion to the Bible.* An *illusion* creates a false impression of reality. *Magic relies upon illusion, seeing what you believe instead of what is really there.*
A lot	*A lot* is always two words meaning "much" or "many." *Alot* is a misspelling.

TABLE H4

Confusing Words	Definitions and Examples
apart, a part	*Apart* denotes a separation. *Social distancing requires people to stand six feet apart from each other. A part* denotes a segment of something. *The dog is a part of our family.*
bare, bear	As verbs, *bare* means "to uncover." *Bear* means "to endure." *Bear with me while I bare my soul.*
complement, compliment	*Complement* means "to add to" or "to complete." *Compliment* means "to make an approving remark." *Many people now compliment the fresh gray paint that complements the exterior stone on the house. Complimentary* also means "free" or "without cost." *Because they sold advertising space for the newspaper, they received complimentary tickets to the game.*
conscience, conscious	*Conscience* is a noun that refers to the awareness of one's actions being right or wrong. *I have a guilty conscience. Conscious* is an adjective meaning "awake" or "alert." *She remained conscious after hitting her head on the windshield.*
disinterested, uninterested	*Disinterested* means "impartial." *Uninterested* means "not interested." *She was chosen as a disinterested party to hear both sides of the disagreement. Unfortunately, she was uninterested in the dispute.*
elicit, illicit	*Elicit* is a verb meaning "to bring out." *Illicit* means "unlawful." *His claims elicited a response from the mayor about the effort to stop demand for illicit drugs.*
emigrate, immigrate	People *emigrate,* or leave, one country. They *immigrate* to a new country to live. *When my family emigrated from Chile, they immigrated to the United States.*
everyday, every day	*Everyday* is an adjective meaning "common," "ordinary," or "used daily." *Every day* is a noun phrase meaning "every day." *Everyday tasks are ones you do every day, like brushing your teeth and washing dishes.*
farther, further	*Farther* refers to distance. *I can't carry these groceries any farther. Further* means "in addition," "more," and "to a greater extent" and refers to abstractions like time or amount. *I can't discuss this issue any further.*
fewer, less	*Fewer* refers to items that can be counted. *Less* refers to items that cannot be counted: *I have fewer assignments than my roommate, and she has less time than I do. Cacti need less water than other plants.*
good, well	*Good* is an adjective. *That color looks good on you. Well* is an adverb. *Marguerite speaks Chinese well. Well* is used as an adjective only in reference to health. *She looks well after recovering from the flu.*
imply, infer	*Imply* means "to suggest." *Your email implies you're upset. Infer* means "to conclude." *I infer from your email that you're upset.*
its, it's	*Its* is a possessive pronoun. *The dog wagged its tail. It's* is a contraction of "it is" or "it has." *It's my turn. Its* followed by an apostrophe is incorrect.

TABLE H4

Confusing Words	Definitions and Examples
lay, lie	*Lay* means "to put or set something down." *Please lay the books on the table. Lie* means "to be in or move into a horizontal position" or "to be situated." *I need to lie down and rest my eyes. The towns lie near the waterfalls.* Note also that *lay* is the past tense of *lie. I fell asleep as soon as I lay down to rest my eyes.*
lead, led	The past tense of the verb *to lead* is *led.* The noun *lead* (rhymes with *red*) is the metal. *Nina led a group of tourists past the old lead mine.*
lose, loose	*Lose* is a verb meaning to "mislay" or "not win." *I lose a sock every time I do laundry. These teams never lose their games. Loose* means "not tight" or "not secure." *The loose shutters may be unsafe in a storm.*
myself, herself, himself, yourself, ourselves, themselves, yourselves	Do not use the *-self* pronouns in place of a personal pronoun in an effort to sound more formal: *Malia and I* [not *myself*] *wrote the report. The report was written by Malia and me* [not *myself*]. Use the *-self* pronouns in the following situations: *Malia wrote the report herself. She treats herself to brunch on Sundays.*
peak, peek, pique	*Peak* means "a highest point" or "to reach a highest point." *After a difficult climb, the hikers finally reached the peak. Peek* means "a secretive look" or "to take a secretive look." *My brother peeked at his birthday gifts.* As a verb, *pique* means "to spark interest." *The two classes piqued her interest in physics.* As a noun, *pique* also means "irritation." *His pique at her probing questions was obvious.*
precede, proceed	*Precede* means "to go before." *The example that precedes this one is* peak/peek/pique. *Proceed* means "to go forward." *The judge's decision allowed the lawsuit to proceed.*
prejudice, prejudiced	*Prejudice* is a noun that is sometimes used incorrectly in place of *prejudiced*, an adjective. *His outrageous views were highly prejudiced* [not *prejudice*].
principal, principle	*Principal* has several meanings: "a chief or head, particularly of a school," "a capital sum of money," or "first or highest in rank, importance, or value." *Principle* refers to a "rule of conduct or action." *The school principal outlined the principles behind the code of conduct. The small principal in their savings account is not their principal source of income.*
raise, rise	*Raise* means "to lift" or "to grow" and always takes an object. *She raised her hand to tell the story of how she raised three children on her own. Rise* means "to get up" and does not take an object. *Like the sun, the moon rises in the eastern sky.*
set, sit	*Set* means "to put" or "to place" and takes an object. *He set the groceries on the table. Sit* means "to be seated" and does not take an object. *She sits in the same seat for every class.*
than, then	*Than* is used to compare. *I am older than you. Then* indicates time. *Do your homework, and then we'll get pizza.*

TABLE H4

Confusing Words	Definitions and Examples
that, which	*That* is used to introduce information essential to the meaning of a sentence. *The phone that I bought five years ago no longer charges fully. Which* is most often used to introduce information that is nonessential to the meaning of a sentence. *My iPhone 7, which I bought five years ago, no longer charges fully.* (For more on nonessential and essential information, see Editing Focus: Commas with Nonessential and Essential Information.)
that, who, which	Use *that* and *which* to refer to things and most animals. *The tiger that had escaped was found.* Use *who* to refer to people and animals with names. *Doctors who treated COVID-19 patients were often called heroes.*
their, there, they're	*Their* is a possessive pronoun. *There* indicates place. *They're* is a contraction of "they are." *The Smiths rescued their missing cat from that tree over there; they're happy to have him back.*
to, too, two	*To* can be a preposition indicating direction. *I am going to the pool.* Or it can be part of an infinitive (the *to* form of a verb). *I like to swim. Too* means "also" or "excessively." *Do you like to swim too? Two* is a number. *I swim two times every week.*
unique, unusual	*Unique* means "one of a kind." *Unusual* means "uncommon." Saying that something is more unique than something else is incorrect because something unique cannot be compared. Use *unusual* instead when comparing.
weather, whether	*Weather* refers to the state of the atmosphere. *Whether* refers to alternatives. *Whether we attend the game in person or watch it on TV depends on the weather.*
who's, whose	*Who's* is the contraction of "who is" or "who has." *Who's going to the game? Whose* is the possessive form of "who." *Whose backpack is this?*
your, you're	*Your* is the possessive form of "you." *You're* is the contraction of "you are." *You're going to be relieved that I found your earring behind the desk.*

TABLE H4

H 6. Point of View

Point of view refers to the vantage point from which a story, event, report, or other written work is told. The point of view in which you write depends on the genre in which you are writing. For example, you will likely use first person in personal narrative writing. For most academic writing, you'll use third person. (See Editing Focus: Characterization and Point of View for a related discussion of point of view in narrative writing.)

First Person

In the first-person point of view, the writer or narrator (*I, we*) is present in the writing. First person is commonly used in personal writing genres, such as literacy narratives, memoirs, and profiles, as well as in fiction.

> After midnight—my paper started, my exam studied for—I leave the library and head back to my apartment. In the dark, I listen closely when I hear footsteps behind me, and I step to the edge of the sidewalk to let a man pass. At my door, I fumble for my key, open the door, turn on the light, and step inside. I am safe, ready to eat, read a bit, and return to my paper.